kíkik

xyh

a s alaaalaalas a a a aa
a lallaal a a s sla s a asaa a ll o
l a l a aaalaosa la al a s s c
ss l h s a h oo oaa s ol a s o a sa ss o
s o nc o c o s hc a o o o h o ohh a s
oac h o a s s ochos h o c cos ha oc h
so hh o 夏 ocで a h c c s n o oo夏 h
夏 h hhoh o a 夏 ooh夏 c 夏a 夏 夏
o 夏a oで n夏nすn夏 o 夏 す で夏 夏 h夏n
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d oo夏 sすa s n on o os す da o
n ob n os syo y y, ybao , oy yo nab b ,
ba b a bo , by a y yy baya b y y ay b
b ab,yayy aa a n a ,yyaa a b n
bay ay aa a a aa a aaaaa a y y a y
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l cc so sr e nlo m oe kmk lmr mck kr a k
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rr n an n n a aa a n a na aa n
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In Hiligaynon, "kíkik" means cicada.

I recorded cicadas outside my former home here in the Philippines in 2016. I guess I was just collecting field recordings to use in music, but it was also a recording of that particular place and time. A cicada chorus is specific to its trees and time of day. Diliman, where I recorded it, is one of the few green areas in Metro Manila, which is built densely enough that green space has become scarce. I no longer live in that house now, and I hear other noises, and sometimes other insects.

I am Filipino/Ilonggo-Japanese. I have moved often and also been unable to move when I wanted to many times in my life. I have experiences both as the one transferring, and the one being left behind. I think, even when I wanted to leave a place, I'd catch myself in the middle of my thought and feeling, and think, this moment, this place, will never be again exactly what it is right now. The noise around a place is part of what makes it that place, and it changes when you leave and when you come back. Cicadas in both Filipino and Japanese cultures act as clocks.

The text on the page is made from the cicada recording. I wrote a poem first in Hiligaynon, Japanese, and English, and mapped their characters to the chirps of the cicada recording computationally through granular synthesis. My detector found 22,639 separate chirps in 4 minutes 43 seconds of the recording. The poem is a kind of grid in which each character cell or space stands for about a tenth of a second. A character is printed on a cell when it detects a chirp. The character comes from whichever line of the poem is being scanned at the moment, and it samples a span of characters in a rolling window, resulting characters being smeared and swarm-like across the text.

alas ocho na	it is eight o'clock
夏です	it is summer
dandansoy, bayaan ta ikaw	Dandansoy, I will leave you
1年	one year
it's 8 o'clock	
summer na naman	it is summer again

The third line quotes “Dandansoy,” a traditional Ilonggo folk song about leaving. This piece also has an audio counterpart.